

RURAL CENTER REDI TRAINING

Cross-Sector Collaboration

Sometimes the Only Lifeline to Economic Development

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TODAY'S SPEAKER

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What Are Cross-Sector Collaboratives?

Addressing complex challenges too immense for any one organization or sector to solve alone.



Diverse Expertise

Cross-sector collaboratives bring together nonprofit, for-profit, and government sectors.



Shared Resources

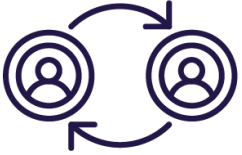
They leverage shared information, resources, and capabilities to find solutions.



Know the Landscape

Understanding who is doing what is crucial to moving the work forward.

Foundational Principles



Peer Learning

Collaboratives over-perform when they can learn about promising practices from others, work toward shared goals, and overcome common challenges together.



Evidence-Based Action

Collaboratives choose actions that are primarily motivated by what is known to be effective while rigorously evaluating new and experimental approaches.

Foundational Principles



Network of Networks

Collaboratives constantly build social capital by developing connections between individuals and organizations, increasing their capacity and available resources.

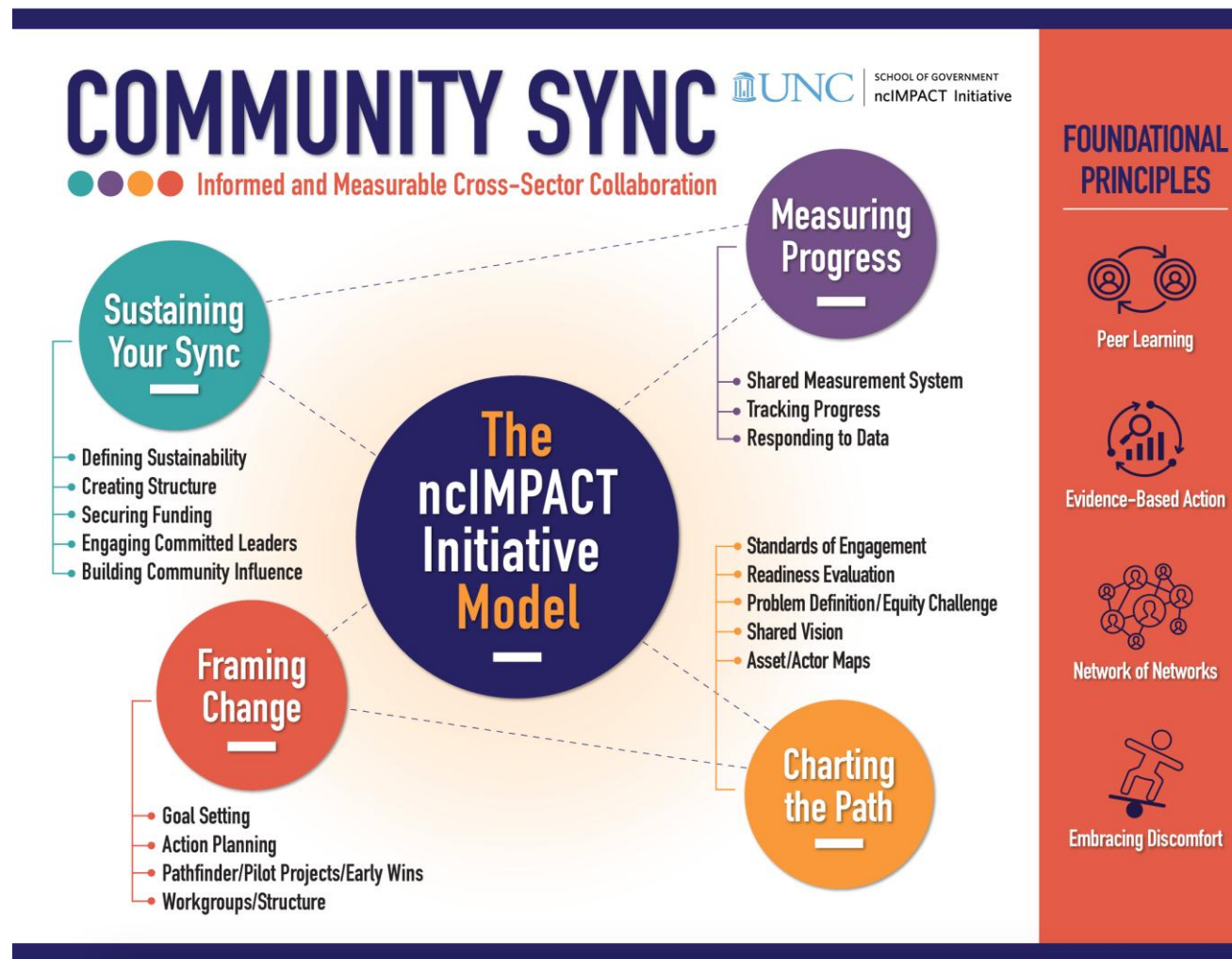


Embracing Discomfort

Collaboratives recognize the challenge of working across organizations and sectors but value the opportunity to engage and learn from varied perspectives.

The Model

50+ cross-sector collaboratives facilitated across North Carolina, refined into one evidence-based model — blending Collective Impact and Strategic Doing in a non-linear way, focused on what works for diverse stakeholders.



THE COMMUNITY SYNC FRAMEWORK

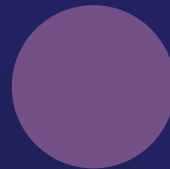
Four Interconnected Components



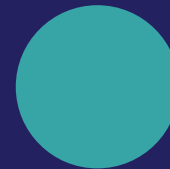
Charting
the Path



Framing
Change



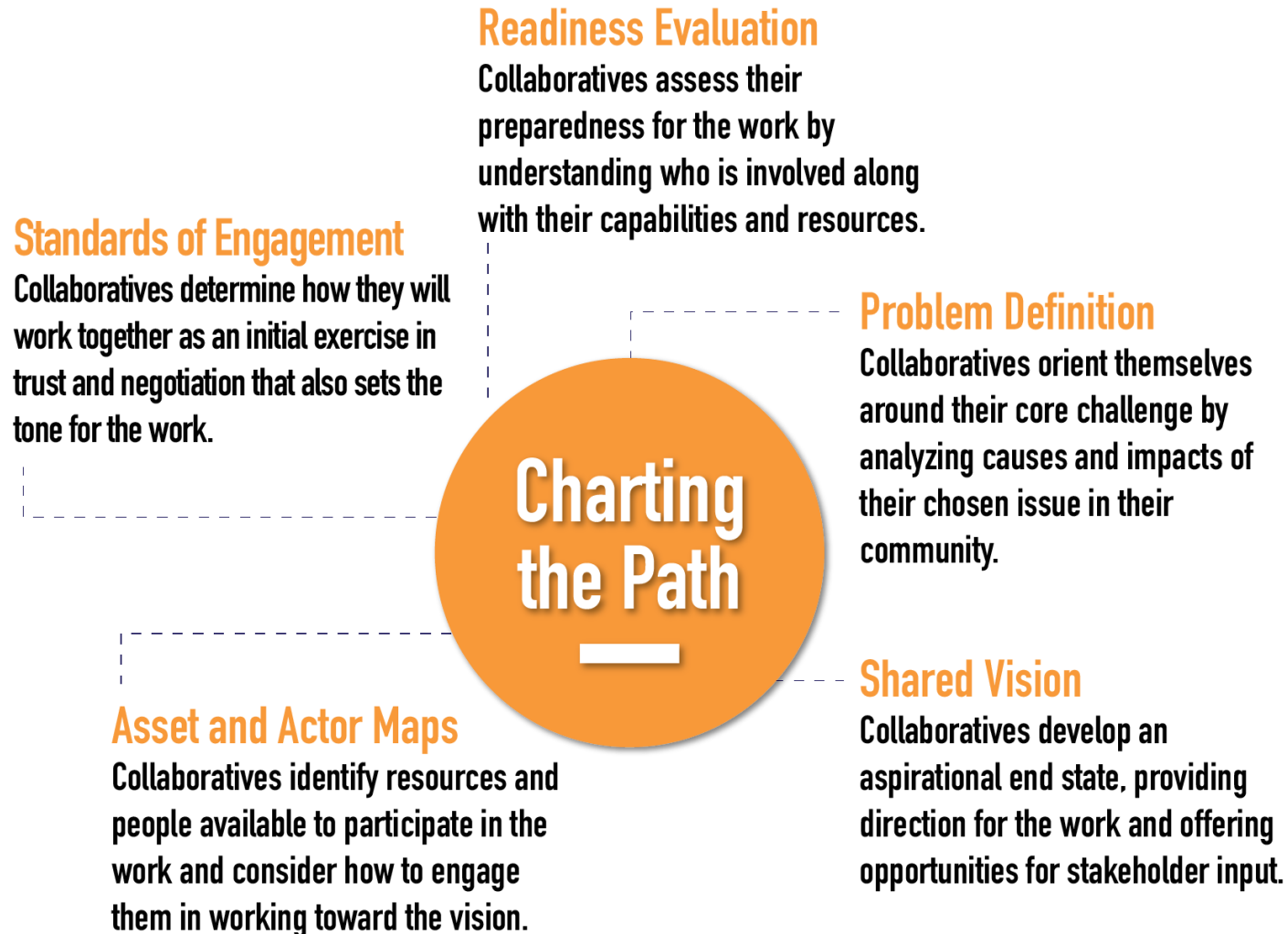
Measuring
Progress



Sustaining
Your Sync

This model emphasizes learning by doing — simultaneous planning and action.
Early wins build confidence and momentum.

The Community Sync Framework — Charting the Path





ON YOUR OWN, IN YOUR COMMUNITY

An aging, inadequate housing stock that no longer meets current residents' needs or supports the businesses and talent we want to attract.

Barriers to workforce recruitment

Fewer options to age in place

High costs & energy inefficiency

Undermined neighborhood stability

Who's Missing from the Table?

Using the housing challenge, consider who would need to be part of a collaborative in your community that works on the issue.

1

BRAINSTORM

2 MIN

Identify 3 people, organizations, or sectors that will be key to the success of a collaborative in your community.

2

PRIORITIZE

1 MIN

Choose the ONE of those actors that will be difficult to engage. Why?

3

MAKE THE CASE

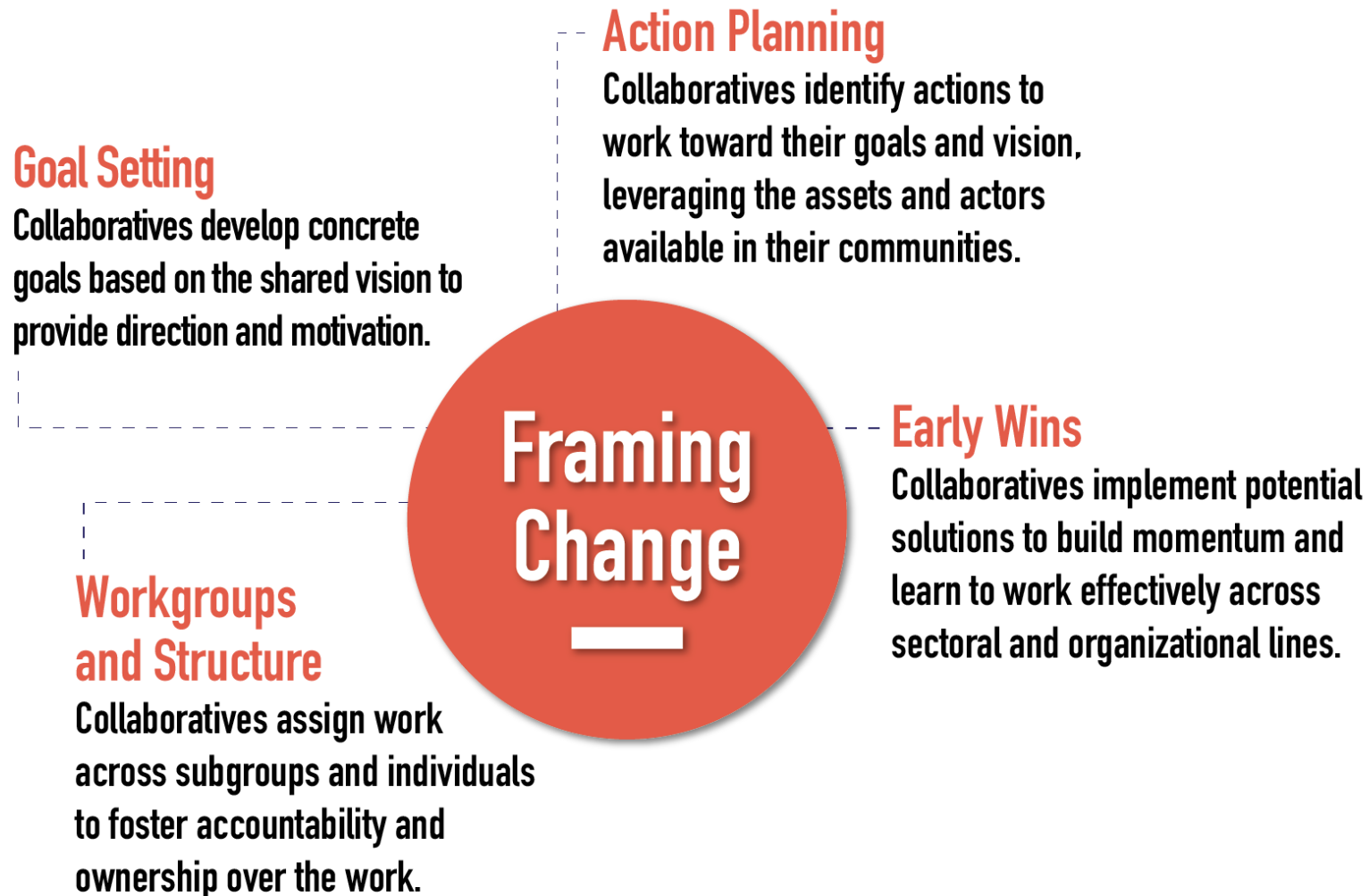
2 MIN

What does that actor contribute? What might motivate them to participate? Who could help bring them to the table?

REPORT OUT

Whom did you choose — and why?

The Community Sync Framework — Framing Change



SCENARIO SETUP

Get into Groups of Four

Your group has convened a cross-sector collaborative to develop comprehensive, coordinated strategies that transform local housing stock from a liability into an asset.



**Municipal & county
government**



**Employers facing workforce
housing challenges**



**Community development
institutions**



**Nonprofits serving
unhoused residents**



Healthcare systems



Educational institutions



Utility providers



**Neighborhood
representatives**

Note: There are currently no real estate developers in the community.

Turn the Challenge into a SMARTIE Goal

“Improve the community’s housing stock” gives us direction but isn’t yet an actionable goal.

1 CHOOSE A FOCUS — 2 minutes

What part of the housing challenge will your collaborative address?

2 DRAFT YOUR GOAL — 8 minutes

Make it:

Specific

Measurable

Ambitious

Realistic

Time-bound

Inclusive

Equitable

REPORT OUT

Share your SMARTIE goal with the group.

EXAMPLE

By the end of 2027, increase participation in the annual county pie-eating contest, with at least one participant from every zip code in the county and free entry for anyone facing cost barriers.

The Community Sync Framework — Measuring Progress

Shared Measurement System

Collaboratives develop a set of shared metrics for success to evaluate progress within teams and across the peer group.



Measuring Progress

Responding to Data

Collaboratives adjust their work based on metrics of progress, doing more of what has been effective and doing less of what has not.

Tracking Progress

Collaboratives report on progress toward their goals to keep themselves accountable and celebrate successes.

Create Shared Measures

Six months from now, your collaborative will review its progress toward your SMARTIE goal.

1

BUILD YOUR DASHBOARD — 4 minutes

Choose 3 measures that, together, would give your collaborative a useful picture of progress toward your SMARTIE goal.

1 . _____ 2 . _____ 3 . _____

2

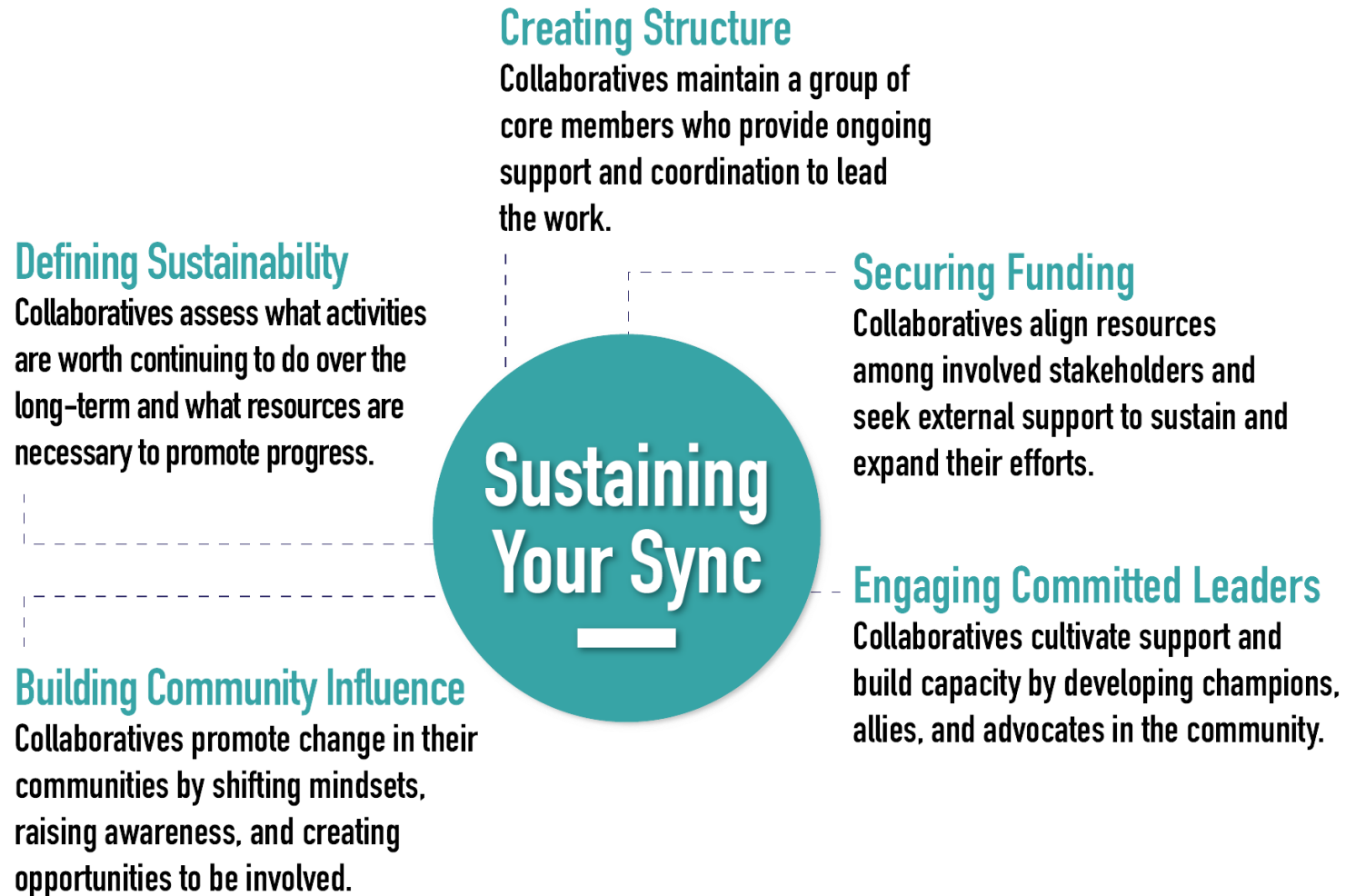
PUT IT TO THE TEST — 4 minutes

Imagine all three measures improve. Would you feel confident telling the community you're making meaningful progress? If not, revisit your dashboard.

REPORT OUT

Share your three measures — and why you selected them.

The Community Sync Framework — Sustaining Your Sync



Keep the Momentum Going

Your collaborative has been working on the housing challenge for one year. Some things have changed:

- Several partners remain highly engaged
- The coordinator is leaving their organization
- Initial funding ends in six months

YOUR CHALLENGE — as a group, identify 3 actions you would take:

Leadership

How will you address the loss of the coordinator?

Resources

How will you prepare for the end of funding?

Engagement

How will you keep partners invested?

REPORT OUT

What would you do first — and why?

PAST & CURRENT COHORTS

ncIMPACT's Collaborative Programs

We apply the Community Sync Model to a range of critical issues.



Opioid Response Project

Reducing stigma, increasing awareness, and improving access to treatment.



myFutureNC LEACs

Increasing the number of students with post-secondary credentials.



Our State, Our Work

Connecting Opportunity Youth to living-wage jobs.



Our State, Our Wellbeing

Addressing mental health challenges and preventing suicides.



Our State, Our Homes

Developing strategies for affordable housing.



Our State, Our Future

Open to living-wage jobs, mental health, and affordable housing.

READINESS CHECK

When Is a Collaborative a Good Idea?

Use this checklist to determine if you are ready for the process.



Is there consensus on the problem?



Is there general agreement on the reasons for the problem?



Are there committed, persistent leaders?



Does trust exist, or can it be built?



Is there human and financial capacity to coordinate the work?



BENEFITS OF A SUCCESSFUL
COLLABORATIVE

Increased Awareness

Deeper understanding of the issue and local systems.

EXAMPLE

“Huge reduction of stigma and a huge increase in awareness” for Opportunity Youth.



BENEFITS OF A SUCCESSFUL
COLLABORATIVE

Shared Accountability & Risk

Fosters creativity and innovation across the collaborative.

EXAMPLE

LEACs evaluated their structure and productivity against their goals.



BENEFITS OF A SUCCESSFUL
COLLABORATIVE

Increased Capacity

Individual, organizational, and community-wide.

EXAMPLE

Opioid Response Project participants reported “significantly higher levels of individual capacity.”



BENEFITS OF A SUCCESSFUL
COLLABORATIVE

Resource Acquisition

Collaboratives are more competitive for external grants and funding.



Supercharging the Process

12–24 months of guidance, coaching, and expert connections.



Stakeholder Engagement

We help identify and sustain the right people at the table.

EXAMPLE

Ensuring employers' consistent engagement in LEACs.



Community Visibility & Legitimacy

Building public trust and buy-in.

EXAMPLE

CX100 helped teams make information “available and accessible.”



Evidence and Expertise

We provide a menu of evidence-based strategies and help communities apply their own local expertise.



Infrastructure & Implementation

Financial support for a program manager and a co-designed Shared Measurement System (SMS) for data-driven decisions.

CONCLUSION

Cross-sector collaboratives offer real hope for tackling complex challenges.

- They require a common vision, a clear action plan, a shared measurement system, and a pathway to sustainability.
- This work is powerful — but not for the “faint of heart.”
- The ncIMPACT Community Sync Model provides a proven framework to guide communities toward collective success.

COMING THIS SPRING

Spring Sync Course

Want hands-on guidance applying the Community Sync Model in your own community? Join us this spring.

DATE

[to be announced]

COST

[to be announced]

Details forthcoming — check ncIMPACT.org for updates.



Questions?

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#nclIMPACT

